



not wrong to say that it's a solution to the problem the telecom companies created themselves. Moreover, this can also be seen as an early signal that Jio intends to follow Airtel down the same prepaid price hike path.

A source confirmed that Airtel is currently not planning to launch anything similar. Rather, they want to see how this stint from Jio works.

Numbers behind the duopoly

The telecom industry has spent years telling India that ARPU is too low, with Airtel among the louder voices. Gopal Vittal has argued that low pricing hurts returns and that 'tariff correction' is necessary to fund network investments, spectrum and infrastructure. There is some merit to that argument; telecom is an expensive business. But the numbers suggest the 'low ARPU' narrative has become less about survival and more about how much more consumers can be made to pay.

Airtel's ARPU has climbed from Rs 178 in FY2022 to Rs 264 in the June

2026 quarter. Jio reached Rs 215.6, while Vi currently stood at Rs 19. The gap is now difficult to ignore as Airtel and Jio have achieved significant scale, with no comparable third player.

The subscriber and market share numbers also back up our claim. According to TRAI's June 2026 subscription report, Jio's wireless subscriber base stood at 503.6 million users, giving it a 39.27% market share.

Airtel followed with about 486.8 million subscribers and a 37.96% share. Vi held 198.8 million subscribers, which is a 15.50% share, and BSNL held 93 million subscribers, about a 7.25% share in the market. Combined, Jio and Airtel now control close to 77% of India's wireless subscriber base.

The Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI) is a simple way to measure how concentrated a market is. It is calculated by squaring each company's market share and then adding those numbers. Using the June 2026 metrics, Jio at 39.27%, Airtel at 37.96%, Vi at 15.50%, and BSNL at 7.25% gives an HHI of about 3,276. The US DoJ considers a market with an HHI above 2,500 to be 'highly concentrated'.

Regulatory context

In India, two key bodies responsible for monitoring such matters are TRAI and the Competition Commission of India (CCI). Given the level of market concentration, continued monitoring by

the authorities would be appropriate. There has been no clear indication of any specific regulatory review focused on the rising concentration.

The authorities could closely monitor further tariff increases and could intervene to provide clear explanations for significant price changes so that things get transparent for the users as well. Moreover, the CCI could also assess whether the current market structure presents any risks of abuse of market power or other forms of anti-competitive behaviour.

BSNL and Vi are sitting out

Let's now talk about the other two players, BSNL and Vi, as they have not joined this round of hikes, and the reason is not generosity. As previously mentioned, the telecom operators have their hands full with other issues.

Telecom expert Faisal Kawoosa, the founder and chief analyst at Techarc, said, 'These two operators are at a different altitude right now, lower in orbit in performance, finances and customer base. They cannot be among the first to make any upward tariff revisions'. He also added, 'I am pretty sure at least Vi will follow, if not BSNL, which still has shades of a public sector enterprise and will go by its complex decision-making process.'

What do experts believe?

Faisal believes operators have stopped chasing growth in their overall user base and started chasing premium, high-spending customers instead, a shift he has also noticed playing out in real estate, cars, and consumer electronics. He points to a harder truth behind this shift too: 5G has not delivered the returns operators were hoping for, so raising ARPU has become one of the few realistic ways left to recover that investment before spending on 6G begins. ■



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